kept a doll on his desk, a man dressed in a long black coat and top hat. When you pressed a button, the doll tried to punch you. “Just like the ultra-Orthodox,” he once told an interviewer).[4]

Two years later, though, Lapid’s star had waned. He had achieved little during his stint as finance minister, a job that is often a poisoned chalice. “Israelis never like the man who takes their money,” explained one of his colleagues. Moshe Kahlon, the popular ex-communications minister who oversaw the mobile phone reforms, stole Lapid’s spotlight when he launched his own centrist socioeconomic party (with better ideas). And some of Lapid’s center-left supporters rallied behind Herzog, who seemed to have a shot at unseating Netanyahu. He fell to 11 seats.

Lapid has based his political career on trying to find the exact center of Israeli public opinion. “We’re not a center-left party,” Yair Zivan, one of his advisers, said over coffee in north Tel Aviv. “This isn’t between left and right. It’s between left, right, and center, and most Israelis are still in the center.” In practical terms, this means Lapid works hard to avoid being tainted with even a whiff of the left. Anshel Pfeffer, my colleague at *The Economist*, called him a “wannabe Netanyahu.” Dimi Reider, an Israeli journalist and analyst, memorably dubbed him “tofu man”, a television star “who avoided taking any remotely controversial stand on almost any issue.”

Though he sits in the opposition, he often refuses to criticize the government: “we’re an alternative, not the opposition,” in Zivan’s words. Sometimes he serves as an unofficial foreign minister, jetting around Europe and North America to meet with senior Western officials. He took credit when the mayor of London removed pro-BDS ads from the Underground in February 2016. “I approached London mayor Boris Johnson, who’s a great friend of Israel, and explained that the state of Israel will not accept this,” Lapid said afterwards. In August of that year he traveled to Stockholm for a public rally, where he led a small crowd in chants of “we love Israel!”

On the Palestinians, he speaks largely in platitudes, with talk of “regional initiatives” and “involving the Arab states”. Like Herzog, he prefers to avoid the issue whenever possible. In a meeting with the foreign press in December, he suggested that a left-wing British newspaper was the real reason for the impasse in peace talks. “The problem is that the Palestinians are encouraged by *The Guardian* and others saying we don’t need to do